



The Gordon Family Plot

By Krista Wentworth

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It is no secret that Mt. Hope cemetery holds many gems, each with their own story to tell. However, there remain many stories that still need to be told. Here is one of them. This is the story of the Gordon Family, one of the pioneer families in Brockport, who not only left a significant impact on our community, but also continue to do so, even today. The family's influence can be seen starting with just a glimpse of their plot found in all Lot 61 Range 2, which boasts a stunning monument with columns in the center, and on top, with an allegorical figure with beautiful drapery. She has one hand across her heart and the other clutching a cross by her side. Her gaze is off into the distance, as if she, too, is mourning the loss of each member of the family with their names inscribed upon on the modest stones below.

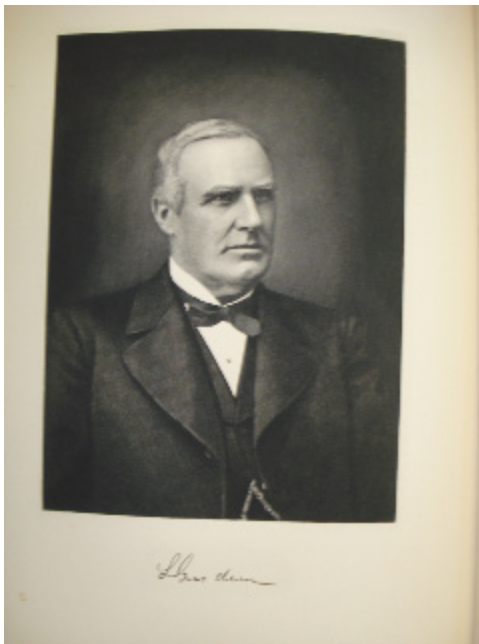
The plot was purchased by Luther Gordon. His son, George C. Gordon, later paid \$9,229.54 for perpetual care

of the plot in 1883 (Trust and Investment Division). He is also the member of the family who can be credited with bringing the Gordon's to Rochester. James Gordon, his grandfather, came from Scotland (Peck, 1029). His



father, John Gordon, was from Vermont, and his mother Harmony Woodworth was from Connecticut. They visited Rochester to purchase land, but thought the offer they received of four dollars an acre was too high. So, they moved along to be one of the first settlers in

Allegany County (McIntosh, 165). It was here that Luther Gordon was born. His father passed away when Luther was nineteen years of age, and Luther quickly stepped up to the challenge of the business world at quite a young age. He conducted business in general merchandise for fourteen years, and spent sixteen years in the stock business.



Here, he would buy from the Eastern markets in the summer months and work in the lumber trade in the winter. In all his years in business, he never saw a loss. He had a strong willed business ethic, and this certainly helped lead to his success. In fact, he never used agents, always conducted all the elements of business himself (Peck, 1030), and “never smoked or drank as a rule” (Mcintosh, 166). In this fashion, he closely oversaw the on-

goings of his business transactions. In 1856 he purchased the lumber business firm of Baswell, Walker & Hood, where he continued to have good success and eventually added saw mills in Brockport (Peck, 1030). Furthermore, he worked side by side with his brother in the lumber industry; together, they had extensive timberland investments, with over 7,000 acres in Michigan (Andrews, 75).

His success in business opened up many other avenues for him, and he eventually founded the First National Bank of Brockport and soon thereafter became its president. This bank was the repository for canal tolls that were collected in Brockport (Andrews, 76). Since the canal brought a significant amount of revenue into the city of Rochester during this time period, this was yet another wise business decision on Luther Gordon’s

part. In fact, it was so successful that they were soon able to erect a new building for the bank in 1873 (Mcintosh, 166). However, Luther Gordon was even more involved in the community than can be seen through his business, lumber, and banking endeavors. It was through his influential political positions that his true impact on the area was able to be exerted. Luther Gordon was

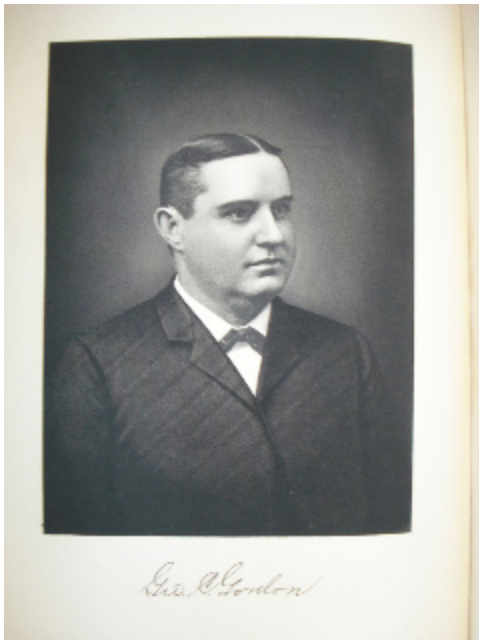


elected to the Brockport Board of Trustees in 1861 (“Brockport Board of Trustees”), and eventually accepted the liberal nomination for Congress from the local district in 1872. When his letter of acceptance was published in the Union and Advertiser on October 24, 1872, the paper had wonderful things to say about him: “Luther Gordon is a man of the people... a laborer in the field of industry and a producer of wealth” (“Luther Gordon Accepts Nomination”).

Though he did not win the election, it remains clear that Luther Gordon was a man of many successes and was much respected by his peers. He greatly impacted the town of Brockport through his thriving businesses, banking, as well as politics. Through all of these methods, Luther Gordon was able to pave the way for the rest of the Gordon family to continue to build on his efforts and contributions. Luther died in 1881 due to typhoid pneumonia, and his wife, Florilla Gordon, passed away in 1869 from consumption at age forty-one. They are buried together in the plot (Mt. Hope and Riverside Cemetery Records).

Upon Luther's passing, his only son, George C. Gordon who was born in July of 1849, carried on Luther's visions as he succeeded his father not only in his business interests, but also as a respected member of the community (Andrews, 76). A biography of George C. Gordon from 1908 released in the book In Rochester & Monroe County described George C. Gordon as "a man of great strength of character, of high purpose and lofty principles" (Clarke, 171). He was nine years old when his family moved from Rushford to Brockport, where he attended the Collegiate Institute and Rochester Academy.

As he had been put to work in the bank from a young age, it was not long before he joined his father in his other business endeavors as well. In fact, the Daily Union and



Advertiser published on July 23, 1863 shows us that Luther had his son at work from quite a young age. At age fifteen, he was working at the banking office of Waters, Bishop & Co. as an attendant when a man asked him to change a ten dollar bill. All was fine and well until "he was felled by a blow upon the head, dragged into the bank vault and the lock turned upon him" ("Bold Bank Robbery"). When he was found, he was

"severely beaten upon the head, and was bleeding from a wound" and five thousand dollars had been stolen. ("Bold Bank Robbery"). But, even an encounter such as this one with bank bandits did not stop George C. Gordon from carrying on the Gordon family's

influential role in the Brockport community as well as working side by side with his father.

George C. and his father, Luther, certainly spent much time together as business partners, as well as father and son. The family lumber business was soon renamed “Luther Gordon & Son.” Upon his father’s passing away, George C. not only succeeded him in this organization, but also as the President of the First National bank of Brockport (Peck, 1050). He continued on in this position until his own death. But, he did not simply bask in the successful path his father left him; instead, he “enlarged and extended his operations and in all displayed most sound judgment, which was rarely, if ever, at fault” (Clarke, 171).

George C. Gordon also held many highly esteemed positions within important industries Western New York throughout his life. He was president of the Brockport Loan and Building Association and a trustee of the Fidelity Trust Company of Buffalo, New York. He did not, however, become this successful completely on his own. Instead, he entrusted his wife Miss Ida M.

Hooker, who he married on October 18th, 1875, with much support and aid throughout his endeavors (1875 United States Federal Census). She also held



influential positions within the city of Rochester; for example, she was the President of Rochester Children’s Nursery (Clarke, 171). She was also one of two women appointed to the SUNY Brockport Board of Trustees in 1917 (“History of Campus Buildings”). In Ida’s will in 1949, she set forth an extra one thousand dollars to be deposited with the

City Treasurer of the City of Rochester in which the income from the deposit would be used for the Gordon family burial lot's flowers and plants (Foos). This was a further addition to the perpetual care of the lot that Luther Gordon, her father in law, purchased many years before.

Ida Hooker and George C. Gordon worked together throughout their lifetime to greatly influence their community. Their bond continued until George C. Gordon passed away due to a hemorrhage of the stomach, and predeceased his wife by almost fifty years (Mt. Hope and Riverside Cemetery Records). The obituary published in the New York Times on August 26, 1898 reveals many of his lasting influences on the community as well as how he carried out many of his father's interests, namely banking, and lumber, until the time of his death:

George C. Gordon, the millionaire banker of Brockport, died yesterday at his summer Residence at Troutburg, on the shore of Lake Ontario. He had been President of the First National Bank of Brockport since 1881. Besides the banking business, Mr. Gordon possessed large holdings of real estate in Western New York as well as large lumber interests in the west....

Clearly, George C. Gordon and his wife made quite an impact on Rochester. In



fact, their influence can still be seen in various places throughout the Rochester area today. At St. Luke's church in Brockport, there is a Tiffany window made by Louis C. Tiffany in 1927. It is of a religious theme, and was dedicated to the memory of George C. and Ida Hooker ("Tiffany Treasures at St. Luke's Brockport"). Their son, Luther Gordon, was treasurer of St. Luke's at this time

and most likely over saw the construction and funding of the window (Clarke, 238).

Furthermore, there is a building at the State University of New York at Brockport called

“Gordon Hall” and is named after George C. and his wife. It was dedicated in 1966 in

their honor since they provided financial support

right after the war, which was a vital point in time

for SUNY Brockport (“History of Campus

Buildings”). After George C. Gordon’s passing,

there was a George C. Gordon Cup for children at

the 1921 Rochester Exposition and Horse Show (Stone). His wife, Ida M. Hooker may

have established this in his honor for she was involved with children in Rochester.



George C. Gordon and Ida Hooker’s legacy continued through their five children,

Luther; George Cooley; William H., Fred H.; and Thomas C (Clarke, 171). Of these

children at least one, William H. Gordon, died in infancy (Mt. Hope and Riverside



Cemetery Records). His stone is prominently placed in the plot right as one walks up the steps, directly below the angel. This is different from the rest of the stones in the plot, as the others follow a square perimeter layout. The inscription on

his stone affectionately calls him “Willie,” and shows that he lived just over six months

from September of 1879 until February of 1880.

George C. Gordon and Ida M. Hooker's son Luther Gordon Jr., is also buried in the family plot at Mt. Hope. Upon George's passing, Luther, who was born in 1875, succeeded him in the banking and lumber businesses. Luther and his brother George C. Jr., who is not buried in the plot, had been enrolled in the University of Rochester but they both withdrew at the time of their father's death to carry out the family businesses. They were both set to graduate in 1899, but withdrew in 1898 (Gordon, Luther Jr. Updated Alumni Records at the University of Rochester). However their time at the University of Rochester was not uneventful. Both Luther and his brother were members of the UR Glee and Mandolin Clubs, Luther Gordon playing guitar, and George Jr. played second mandolin (Personal Scrapbook of George C. Gordon Jr.). Their club traveled performing throughout the east coast, including when in Cleveland for a young lady who had been invalid for seven years ("UR Glee and Mandolin Clubs Spring Trip"). Even as college students, the Gordon brother's ambition and good deeds were prevalent.

But, with their father passing away, both brothers began working at the bank; Luther as president and George Jr. as assistant cashier and later Vice President and Treasurer (Gordon, Luther Jr. Updated Alumni Records at the University of Rochester). Luther sold the lumber business in 1932 to the firm's former manager, WEB Stull, who continued the business on his own. Stull Lumber is still active on Park Avenue in Rochester (Andrews, 77). Luther remained involved with the bank as President from 1898 to 1921 when he passed away from a tumor at age forty-nine (Mt. Hope and Riverside Cemetery Records).

After Luther Jr.'s passing, another one of George's sons stepped forward to become the bank president, Thomas Gordon. Thomas replaced the 1873 building with its

present Neo-classical structure that is now housing the Chase Manhattan Bank. Another one of his achievements is still found in Rochester. He built greenhouses at his home on West Avenue. They were originally a hobby, but soon became a business as well. Today, this establishment is Roger's Flower shop and Green houses (Andrews, 77).

Thomas Gordon had many other achievements as well. He studied at Yale for



three years, and was trustee of the village of Brockport from 1914-1920. He also was Chairman of the board of Water commissions from 1915-1920, and mayor from 1920-1922. He was a local leader of the Republican Party and spent ten years as chairman of the Town Republican Committee. Thomas was very much involved in the community, and his interests spread far and wide. He served as treasurer at St. Luke's Episcopal Church, of which, he was a long time member. Similarly, he belonged

to many community societies including the Yale Club, State Banker's Association, and Delta Phi Greek (Clarke, 238). He and his wife had two sons, Thomas C. Jr. and William Ward who were also able to help carry out their family's legacy of success and influence.

One of George C. Gordon's other son's, Fred Gordon, is not in this plot. He did, however, have a prominent influence western New York. He worked for the family at the bank until 1910. But, he ended up taking his own path. Fred was owner of the Whitehall farms in Clarkson, which is just north of the village of Brockport (Andrews, 77). Like many in his family, he was also involved in a wide variety of social circles (Clarke, 238). He had two sons who also have continued on the Gordon family history of being

prominent in the community. One of them, Lucius Gordon, or “Bob” as he was more



commonly called, was a major benefactor of Rochester Institute of Technology for over seven decades, served as a trustee, received an RIT honorary doctorate, and has the Gordon Field House and Activities Center

named after him and his wife (“Remembering Lucius ‘Bob’ Gordon, RIT Trustee and Benefactor: 1912-2008”). This is simply one example of how the legacy of the Gordon family has continued to remain strong generations after the initial contributions made by Luther Gordon.

The Gordon family’s significant impact on the Rochester area can still be seen today, not only in the way they shaped and changed the business industry, banking, real estate, and politics of our community, but also in their many contributions that surround us. This family that has continued to give back to the community, and has exerted tremendous influence through a wide variety of venues in the town of Brockport and the wider western New York area. Their monument that stands surrounded by small, humble stones in the middle of Mt. Hope cemetery speaks to their achievements, success, and society’s grave loss of each of these individuals.



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Speaking Stones Papers in UR Research:

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1. Luther Gordon (1822-1881), Grandfather
 2. George C. Gordon (1849-1898), Father
 3. Ida Hooker Gordon (1855-1946), Mother
 4. Thomas Gordon (1884-1960), Son
 5. Luther Gordon, Jr. (1875-1923), Son
- And other family members

Keywords:

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- First National Bank of Brockport
- family history
- St. Luke's Church

Brief Abstract:

Description and history of the Gordon family, including Luther Gordon (1822-1881), his son George C. Gordon (1849-1898) and his son's wife Ida Hooker Gordon (1855-1946). Information on their sons, Thomas Gordon (1884-1960), Luther Gordon, Jr. (1875-1923), and their other children; as well as, details about their lives in banking, politics, and business are included.